an international cricketer, he will feel the same individual or organization tapping him on the shoulder.

'You owe us a favour …'

Dressing-room gossip involves unsubstantiated stories, but I have never been approached to do anything illegal. I did, however, play in one of the most notorious Tests of all, at Lord's against Pakistan in 2010, the setting for the spot-fixing scandal that led to the banning and imprisonment of Salman Butt, Mohammad Asif and Mohammad Amir.

The sting, by undercover reporters from the *News of the World* , who secretly videotaped Mazhar Majeed, a corrupt sports agent, accepting money and promising deliberate no-balls on specific occasions, came at a time when, to be flippant, I couldn't buy a run. The deal was that the first ball of Amir's second over, the last delivery of Asif's fifth and the final ball of the first over in which Amir went around the wicket to a right-hander would be no-balls.

Amir's first one, to me, was so big that either he had completely messed up his run-in or something funny was going on. I thought Asif's was strange, to say the least, but didn't dwell on it, because it was marginal and, unlike the prodigy Amir, who had never overstepped the mark in first-class cricket, he had a history of problems in that area.

We were in a great position that Saturday night. I was caught behind for 10 off Amir on the Friday morning, after rain allowed only twelve overs on the first day. Jonathan Trott's 184 and Broady's only Test century, 169, got us to 446 before we bowled them out for 74. Pakistan had lost four more wickets before the close, by which time, unbeknown to us, the ground was crawling with senior policemen.

The story broke, on an embargo, at 10 p.m. that evening. Suddenly my phone was alive with messages from friends, saying, 'Oh my God, are you watching TV?' I sat in bed, following events on Sky for hours with a sense of disbelief. It even crossed my mind that the match would be abandoned. The following day was one of my most surreal.

Andy Flower's team talk was direct and to the point. 'We've just got a job to do,' he said. 'Turn up, do it, and let everything else fall as it may. We've still got to play our cricket.' The Pakistanis arrived late; we had been in the players' dining room watching TV coverage of their team bus, still parked outside their hotel, wondering whether they would turn up.